



The intent and influence of evaluation policies and strategies in the philanthropic sector

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ABSTRACT

Evaluation policies are being written across the philanthropic sector. These policies offer rules and principles that are intended to guide evaluation practice. However, it is unclear what has motivated the development of evaluation policies and what impact, if any, they have on evaluation practice. Through interviews with 10 evaluation directors at foundations that have written evaluation policies, we identify the intent of these policies and their perceived influence in the philanthropic sector. We conclude with suggestions for future research on evaluation policy.

Research on the philanthropic sector suggests that we may be experiencing “the second golden age of American philanthropy” (Reich, 2018). Of the \$1.2 trillion in total capitalization, U.S. foundations annually distribute over \$90 billion to nonprofit organizations working on nearly every issue area around the world, from disease eradication to homelessness prevention (The Foundation Center, 2021). Foundations collect and share data to assess and demonstrate the extent to which the initiatives they fund are serving the public good. Additionally, in exchange for funding, foundations may mandate that their grantees engage in evaluation.

Evaluation offers a systematic approach to studying an intervention, broadly defined, to better understand its merits and challenges. The information generated is used by foundation staff to understand impact and to inform funding and strategy decisions. The findings, positive or negative, may also be disseminated more broadly to encourage learning across a program sector (i.e., child well-being). As Kramer and Bickel (2004) noted, evaluation also is used in the philanthropic sector as a process for generating evidence for accountability, learning, and knowledge sharing. While these functions are all important, they can be difficult to balance, as Kramer and Bickel (2004) note:

Accountability for use of funds is the most common form of evaluation but contributes little to the learning of the foundation or the broader field. Learning within the foundation is more valuable

though less common and knowledge sharing with the field is critically important, though least common of all. (p. 53)

Perhaps to achieve a better balance, foundations have begun to formalize their evaluation practices, requests, and expectations by drafting evaluation policies that govern when, what, and how to engage in evaluation (Dillman, 2014; Mattessich et al., 2009; Dillman & Christie, 2016; Kinarsky & Christie, 2022).

If evaluation policies authored by foundations are used as intended, then they likely guide evaluation practice across the civic sector, which impacts interest in, demand for, and practices of evaluation. These policies ultimately influence the quality of information generated about the effectiveness of interventions being developed and executed by nonprofit organizations and foundations. While some evaluation policies may help streamline and improve evaluation practice, others may do more harm than good. For example, if a foundation’s policy prioritizes the use of randomized control trials (RCTs) and is not nuanced to program development stage, and thus, for example, de-incentivizes qualitative inquiry, then initiatives that are more targeted or in early development may be forced to participate in RCTs before they are ready or, more likely, they may not get evaluated at all. Despite the importance of this relationship between evaluation policy and practice, there is still little empirical research on this subject.

At their best, evaluation findings impact funders’ perceived value of an initiative and help them prioritize what to fund, including the specific

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programs and services (Datta, 2009). Given that foundations and non-profits work together to improve society, often providing vital services for the most vulnerable and disenfranchised communities, what gets funded is of great importance. Therefore, it is necessary to empirically investigate the evaluation policies being developed by foundations to guide their evaluation practice.

1. Defining evaluation policy

Evaluation policies articulate the rules and principles endorsed by an organization or group that establish the “content, characteristics, and context of evaluation itself” (Mark et al., 2009, p. 5) and guide “decisions and actions when doing evaluation” (Trochim, 2009, p. 19). Closely aligned with the definition of an evaluation policy is Patton’s definition of an evaluation principle. He states, “A good principle provides guidance for making choices and decisions, is useful in setting priorities, inspires, and supports ongoing development and adaptation” (Patton, 2018, p. 13). Thus, the articulation of an explicit set of principles may make up an evaluation policy. Most critical, perhaps, is alignment with an organization’s specific political, organizational, and cultural values, norms, and beliefs about evaluation (Christie & Lemire, 2019).

In the present study, evaluation policy is understood as any written document that details an organization’s rules and principles for evaluation practice, regardless of whether implementation is encouraged or enforced. Trochim (2009) proposed that practices that are encouraged, enforced, or used to guide decisions and actions in evaluation should be treated as policy, regardless of whether they are written down in a policy or not. Christie and Lemire (2019) challenged Trochim’s argument that in addition to explicit policies, evaluation policies can be informal (implicit), and moreover, that for any policy to be actualized it must be enforced. They instead argued that an evaluation policy should be made explicit, regardless of whether there are consequences connected to its implementation. To this point, in a study of explicit and implicit evaluation policies conducted at a large public health foundation, Dillman and Christie (2016) found that even though the foundation did not enforce its policies, those policies still had a meaningful influence on evaluation practice.

2. Understanding the intent of policy

Policies typically arise when problems can benefit from standardized actions (Bardach & Patashnik, 2016; Cochran & Malone, 2010; Munger, 2000). According to Munger (2000), policy formation tends to follow a three-stage process. First, a problem is identified. Once the problem is defined, a discussion ensues as to whether it should be resolved collectively or individually. If it is determined that the resolution should be collective then the policy gets written, either by the stakeholders or with the guidance of experts.

Therefore, prior to exploring the impact of a policy, it is first important to understand what the policy intends to accomplish (Bardach & Patashnik, 2016; Bullock et al., 1983). Only once the motivations of a policy are surfaced can that policy’s impact be appropriately gauged. In this way, evaluation of policies is like evaluation of programs. Before attempting to evaluate the impact of a program, an evaluator seeks to understand why the program was established and what it intends to accomplish. Once the goals are identified, the evaluator can explore connections between goals, practices, and outcomes.

In this article, we explore the goals and objectives motivating the development of evaluation policies in the philanthropic sector. There are notable challenges that may motivate foundations to write evaluation policies. For example, evaluation practice in the philanthropic sector tends to be “ad hoc, not aligned to strategy, underfunded, and underused” (Preskill & Mack, 2013, p. 4). Furthermore, as previously noted, evaluation in the philanthropic sector is used to generate evidence for accountability, learning, and knowledge sharing (Kramer &

Bickel, 2004)—three objectives that can be difficult to balance.

3. The influence of evaluation policies on evaluation practice

There is growing consensus among researchers and practitioners that American philanthropic foundations can benefit from a more strategic approach to evaluation (Buteau & Glickman, 2018; Chelimsky, 2001; Dean-Coffey, 2018; Kramer & Bickel, 2004; Preskill & Mack, 2013). Developing an evaluation policy can provide conceptual clarity in evaluation practice (Hart & Mark, 2022; Christie & Lemire, 2019; Kinarsky & Christie, 2022; Newcomer et al., 2022). Such policies articulate an organization’s “mental model” for evaluation—the ideas, theories, and assumptions that inform evaluation practice within the organization and “determine not only how we make sense of the world, but how we take action” (Senge, 2006, p. 164). This helps stakeholders “define a method of grappling with the situation and ruling out a vast array of possible actions” (Rumelt, 2017, p. 84). Furthermore, an evaluation policy offers coherence to diverse activities, concentrates an organization’s efforts, reduces complexity, and lessens ambiguity (Rumelt, 2017; Senge, 2006).

Emergent theory suggests there is an important relationship between evaluation policy and practice (Christie & Lemire, 2019). Trochim (2009) posited that written evaluation policies encourage consistency of practice, make internal opinions on evaluation public, encourage learning, and allow for adjustments to and innovation in evaluation practice. Thus, policy not only impacts how evaluation is conducted but also influences the quality of information generated. Mark et al. (2009) discussed the importance of policy quality:

Evaluation policy is a critical concern for evaluation practice, in part because it shapes evaluation practice thereby both *enabling and constraining the potential contribution evaluation can make...* At the extreme, evaluation policy may not only enable some forms of contribution and constrain others; bad evaluation policy can have serious negative consequences. (p. 3, emphasis added)

In sum, the scope and quality of an evaluation policy can have a constructive or adverse impact on evaluation practice.

Several empirical studies have examined the impact of evaluation policy on practice. These studies offer critical insights into the importance of evaluation policy, its impact on evaluation practice, and suggestions for future areas of inquiry. To date, several studies traced the impact of federal evaluation policies on national evaluation practice in Europe. Stern (2009) reviewed the evolution of evaluation policy in the executive branch of the European Union and concluded that as evaluation policy shifted so did the purpose or goals of evaluation practice. Evaluation was initially used to inform local project management and program delivery. However, as evaluation policy shifted towards a more national focus, so did practice. Evaluation was no longer being used “to make transparent to the citizens what they are getting for their money” (Bosch, quoted in Stern, 2009, p. 70). It became a tool for appraising policy proposals from an “economic, social and environmental perspective” (p. 74). Likewise, in a review of how Dutch evaluation policy has evolved since the 1970 s, Leeuw (2009) concluded that evaluation policies contributed to an increase in evaluation demand and an expansion of local evaluation units. The national evaluation policy was broad enough to allow local evaluators to make technical and methodological decisions independently. More recently, Marra (2021) conducted an organizational ethnography of Italy’s public administration system as it underwent a performance-based transformation. Marra captured how partisan leadership and adversarial relationships can impede the effectiveness of a national evaluation policy.

A study conducted by Christie and Fierro (2012) inquired into how evaluators interpreted and enacted evaluation policy. Through their case study on the implementation of a California state evaluation policy, they identified an “inherent tension” between written evaluation policy and how evaluators interpreted that policy (p. 71). An evaluator’s

outlook on what “constitutes credible evidence in evaluation”—in addition to challenging logistics during an evaluation—resulted in evaluations that deviated from what was intended by policymakers. We identified one study that explored the connection between policy and practice in the philanthropic sector when starting this work (Dillman & Christie, 2016). The study appraised how evaluation policies of the Robert Wood Johnson Foundation were applied across three initiatives. In this research, evaluation policy standardized some aspects of evaluation practice, but informal policies and guidelines also informed staff decisions and actions. Because of this informality, application was inconsistent and unpredictable.

In 2022 an issue of *New Directions in Evaluation* was published that surveyed the landscape of evaluation policy, primarily at the U.S. federal level, for the first time since 2009. Different from the seminal 2009 *New Directions in Evaluation* issue on evaluation policy, the 2022 issue contains empirical work on evaluation policy, an important step forward in our understandings about evaluation policy and for the field. Included is a case study of the U.S. Department of Labor, describing the development and application of their evaluation policy. Irwin and Nightingale (2022) conclude that the department’s evaluation policy helped “create a language and framework around evidence-building in the department” and was “useful in creating productive relationships with program and policy partners” (p. 107). Focusing on the importance of implementation of evaluation policies, Fierro et al. (2022) outline the different approaches U.S. federal agencies have taken to socialize internal and external stakeholders to evaluation policies. This study serves as a reminder that once written, a thoughtful approach to implementation is necessary to ensure that stakeholders interpret and use evaluation policies as intended. The issue also includes an empirical study of the explicit evaluation policies at international development agencies (Al Hudib & Cousins, 2022). Much like our research on the explicit evaluation policies of foundations (Kinarsky & Christie, 2022), Al Hudib and Cousins (2022) conclude that “evaluation policies are concerned with much more than ‘rules and principles’ as they guide decisions and actions that start before and extend beyond the stage of ‘doing evaluation’ as is suggested by Trochim” (p. 35).

Together, these studies demonstrate that evaluation policies influence evaluation practice in important ways. They can determine the demand for evaluations as well as their strategic focus. At foundations, policies can strengthen evaluation practice by improving alignment. However, policies tend to be interpreted and applied differently by stakeholders. As such, more inquiry is needed to better understand the relationship between evaluation policy and evaluation practice. Motivated by these important gaps in the research, the present paper seeks to understand what is motivating the development of evaluation policies and what impact, if any, they have on evaluation practice in the civic sector. The following research questions guide the present inquiry:

1. According to evaluation directors, what are the primary goals of their foundation’s evaluation policy?
2. According to evaluation directors, in what ways do the foundation’s formal and informal evaluation policies guide evaluation practice?

4. Methods

The present article extends prior analyses of major commissioners of evaluation in the philanthropic sector. Kinarsky (2018) tracked trends in grant funding for evaluation by philanthropic foundations from 2010 through 2014. We used this analysis to identify and review websites of the top commissioners of evaluation in the United States in 2013 and 2014 to locate our sample of publicly available evaluation policies. Once the policies were cataloged and analyzed (Kinarsky & Christie, 2022), we conducted interviews with the evaluation and research directors at 10 foundations to further our understanding of the intent and influence of their evaluation policies. In the remainder of this section, we describe the participants, the study instruments, and the data collection and

analytic procedures.

4.1. Participants

To understand the development and use of evaluation policies, we conducted interviews with evaluation and research directors. Specifically, we invited the evaluation and research directors from the 12 foundations with publicly available evaluation policies (Kinarsky & Christie, 2022) to participate. An individual was eligible for inclusion if they were listed on their foundation’s website with a title indicating they were responsible for overseeing the evaluation function at that foundation. Actual titles varied across foundations; for simplicity, we refer to all participants as “evaluation directors.”

Using contact information found on the foundation websites, we emailed the evaluation directors to request their participation in interviews between December 2017 and February 2018. If there was no response, we made up to two follow-up phone calls or emails. Ultimately, two of the 12 directors declined to participate in the study. One chose not to be interviewed because the foundation no longer used its evaluation policy and because this person was not at the foundation when the policy was developed; the other did not disclose their reason for declining.

We conducted interviews with the evaluation directors at the remaining 10 foundations between February and May of 2018. The participants brought years of academic and professional experience with evaluation to their current roles. Four had graduate degrees in fields related to evaluation. Prior to their current roles, four had worked at large research organizations or universities; three had led evaluation efforts at nonprofits, and three had worked at other foundations. Six directors were employed at their foundations when their policy documents were written and four were not. Table 1 summarizes key information about the study participants and their foundations’ policy documents. Each foundation was assigned an abbreviated name that is listed in Table 1 and used in the remainder of the article.

4.2. Interview procedures

As described above, we conducted semi-structured phone interviews with evaluation directors from 10 foundations. We designed the interview protocol based on the study’s research questions and modified it for each foundation based on analysis of its evaluation policy (Kinarsky & Christie, 2022). For example, if a foundation made explicit mention of a particular theorist or evaluation theory in its policy, this was noted in the protocol and discussed during the interview.

We conducted two pilot interviews to understand how our questions worked under realistic conditions. The first was with a graduate student with expertise in program evaluation; the second was conducted over the phone with an evaluation staff member at a foundation in this study. Following the second pilot, we modified the introduction to the interview to make explicit that the interview was about the foundation’s specific policy document. We also revised some questions to produce an interview protocol that was brief yet detailed enough to answer the research questions.

We employed a semi-structured interviewing approach to allow deviation from the protocol to “respond to the situation at hand” while keeping consistency across interviews (Merriam, 2009, p. 90). In advance of every interview, we re-read the interview protocol and occasionally adjusted it based on another review of the foundation’s evaluation policy and other relevant information from its website (e.g., interviews, publications, blog posts). At least 2 days before each interview, we shared the interview protocol with the participant to help them understand the focus and to give them an opportunity to review their foundation’s evaluation policy.

We conducted the interviews over the phone, and each generally lasted 1 h. The interviews were transcribed verbatim within 2 weeks of completion. At the close of each interview, we invited the participant to

Table 1
Background on Foundations, Evaluation Policies, and Interview Participants.

Foundations		Policy Documents		Study Participants	
Name	Abbreviation	Document Title	Year Written	Job Title	Year Joined Foundation
Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation	Gates	<i>Evaluation Policy</i>	2008	Senior Program Officer for Measurement, Learning, and Evaluation	2016
David & Lucile Packard Foundation	Packard	<i>Guiding Principles and Practices for Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning</i>	2004	Evaluation and Learning Director	2013
Doris Duke Charitable Foundation	Doris Duke	<i>Grant-Making Process: Evaluation</i>	Early 2000 s	Director, Grants Management and Evaluation	2000
Duke Endowment	Duke	<i>Guiding Principles: Learning and Evaluation</i>	2010	Director of Evaluation	2009
John D. & Catherine T. MacArthur Foundation	MacArthur	<i>Our Approach to Evaluation</i>	2010	Managing Director, Evaluation	2011
Kansas Health Foundation	Kansas Health	<i>Evaluation/Learning: Our Approach</i>	In process	Evaluation Officer	2015
Rockefeller Foundation	Rockefeller	<i>Our Strategy: Monitoring and Evaluation</i>	2017	Director, Measurement, Evaluation, and Organizational Performance	2015
Skillman Foundation	Skillman	<i>Evaluation Philosophy and Approach</i>	2007	Director of Evaluation and Learning	2005
Wallace Foundation	Wallace	<i>How We Work: The Wallace Approach</i>	2012	Director of Research	1996
William & Flora Hewlett Foundation	Hewlett	<i>Evaluation Principles and Practices</i>	2012	Evaluation Officer, Effective Philanthropy Group	2013

submit additional documentation related to the foundation's evaluation practices and policy. Documents from eight foundations were cataloged in the study database and used to better understand how evaluation was being practiced at those foundations. We wrote analytic memos after each interview to reflect on emerging findings, future directions, and unanswered questions (Saldaña, 2013).

4.3. Analysis of interview transcripts

Once interviews were completed and transcribed, the data were imported into and analyzed using MaxQDA data analysis software. Following Saldaña (2013), we first generated a priori codes based on the guiding research questions and on findings from the analysis of evaluation policies. We then coded the transcripts using initial coding to closely examine and compare data across interviews. During second-level coding, we utilized pattern coding to "attribute meaning" to the emerging findings (Saldaña, 2013, p. 209). During this coding cycle, major themes surfaced, such as internal and external motivations for policy development. We documented analytic memos of emergent findings and initial reflections in MaxQDA during coding and reviewed them after the second cycle of coding was completed.

After completing the formal coding phase, we generated summary grid in MaxQDA. We reviewed every coded segment and wrote short summary statements. These segments were grouped into categories informed by the research questions and studied for thematic connections (Seidman, 2013). We created visual maps of emerging themes to facilitate the transition from analysis to writing. Analysis continued during the writing process to help further distill themes.

4.4. Validity and trustworthiness

We gave careful attention during interviewing, coding, and interpretation to ensure trustworthiness of findings (Lincoln & Guba, quoted in Seidman, 2013, p. 27). First, we conducted member checks to ensure there were no misunderstandings or inaccuracies in our interpretations (Merriam, 2009). Specifically, we generated a document for each foundation that included background information on the participant and the policy as well as interview quotes and our interpretations. Participants were invited to review the materials and suggest modifications or clarifications, and we reviewed and addressed their suggestions. Next, we wrote analytic memos regularly during interviews and analysis to ensure that emergent patterns, challenges, and questions were tracked. Lastly, we present the findings with quotes to help readers "determine the extent to which their situations match the research context, and

hence whether findings can be transferred" (Merriam, 2009, p. 229).

5. Findings

To date, there has been limited research on why philanthropic foundations develop and share evaluation policies. Understanding the motivations of a policy is a prerequisite to gauging its impact (Bardach & Patashnik, 2016; Bullock et al., 1983). Therefore, the findings section begins with a discussion of what motivated the development of the evaluation policies. We then discuss how these policies have influenced evaluation practice in the foundations. Table 2 summarizes the findings related to the intent and influence of the policies.

In the subsections that follow, we first expand on the internal intentions that motivated the development of evaluation policies (subsections 1–3) before discussing the influence these policies have had within the foundations (subsections 4–7). We then turn to external intent (subsections 8–9) and influence (subsections 10–11). Here, we found that the intent of evaluation policies tended to align with the influence of these policies, for both internal and external stakeholders.

5.1. Internal Intent (1–3)

The most often stated intent for the development and adoption of evaluation policies was the desire to articulate a shared vision for how

Table 2
Intent and Influence of Evaluation Policies.

	Intent	Influence
Internal	1. Communicate evaluation philosophy and practices to an internal audience.	4. Evaluation philosophy is consistently understood and practice is more consistent.
	2. Identify when evaluation practice should remain consistent.	5. Staff know when and how to vary evaluation practice.
	3. Identify when evaluations should vary and how.	6. Evaluation staff have more clarity on how to guide organization-wide evaluation practice.
External	8. Explain evaluation requirements and expectations to grantees.	7. The process of developing an evaluation policy is beneficial.
	9. Communicate evaluation philosophy and practices to external stakeholders.	10. Current and prospective grantees better understand the foundation's evaluation expectations and practice.
		11. Foundations benefit from reviewing and reflecting on each other's policies.

evaluation should be practiced at the foundation. During the interviews or in their policy documents, representatives from all ten foundations stated that their policy's intent was to achieve better alignment around the purpose and practice of evaluation. The need for a policy that creates a shared mental model for evaluation practice emerged because the evaluation function at foundations tended to be decentralized, so decision making around evaluation was dispersed. Evaluation design, execution, and use tends to be reliant on various internal stakeholders, such as the board, president, and program officers, finding consensus. Only one of the 10 foundations had a central evaluation department responsible for executing evaluation and research across the foundation. Two foundations had evaluation staff embedded with program teams. The remaining seven had minimal staff or financial resources dedicated to a central evaluation function. These challenges prompted the development of organizational policies with guidance on how to perform evaluation.

1. Communicate Evaluation Philosophy and Practices to an Internal Audience

We found that the foundations' missions, strategies, and cultures were heavily influenced by their founders, histories, current leadership, and internal expertise. This context shaped how the foundations executed grantmaking as well as their approaches to evaluation. Therefore, their evaluation policies were aimed at connecting their distinct cultures and values to how they executed and used evaluation. As one evaluation director explained:

Drafting guiding evaluation principles is important because it sets the tone. The principles have to match your culture at the foundation, and since every foundation has their own culture, I think being explicit about your assumptions and values around evaluation is important.

Evaluation policies aim to make explicit the ways in which foundations' cultures and values impact the practice of evaluation. This connection between organizational context and evaluation practice was often the first issue probed when conceptualizing an evaluation policy. Internal stakeholders examined how the values and culture of the foundation informed their evaluation practice.

In addition to aligning evaluation practice with their foundations' unique cultures and values, evaluation policies also aim to position evaluation as a vital function of effective grantmaking. Beyond articulating how evaluation is practiced, evaluation policies seek to shape how evaluation is thought about. For example, at the Duke Endowment, leaders wanted the evaluation policy to deter staff from thinking of evaluation narrowly as an audit function. In their policy, they sought to reframe evaluation as a practice that can help grantmakers increase their effectiveness, potentially leading to greater impact in the areas they fund. Thus, an evaluation policy is reflective of an organization's beliefs regarding the importance of evaluation, when and how it should be conducted, and who should be involved.

At foundations with centralized evaluation staff, program officers are typically the ones funding and leading evaluation efforts. Evaluation staff often serve as technical advisors or internal consultants. At these foundations, evaluation directors explained that their policies were meant to educate internal stakeholders and set common parameters for evaluation practice. For example, Kansas Health viewed its evaluation policy (which was still under development) as a tool to communicate what evaluation is and how it should be used to support the work of the foundation. The evaluation director explained:

The [evaluation policy] is a chance for me to write down, "This is our work; this is why we do it; and this is how we do it." Otherwise, there is a lack of understanding and assumptions are made. That is not conducive to a learning environment. It is important that all of us start on the same page about what evaluation is and what it is not.

The word "evaluation" alone, people have different interpretations. It helps to have a shared understanding. Then it can help folks understand how this work can and cannot meet their needs.

In other words, if evaluation is to support a learning environment at the foundation, the director explained, then first, "internally, we need to have the same mental model." Policies seek to make explicit the mental model guiding evaluation practice.

2. Identify When Evaluation Practice Should Remain Consistent

As noted previously, a foundation's responsibility for evaluation is frequently distributed across the organization. Often it is program officers, not evaluation staff, who are responsible for commissioning, designing, and overseeing evaluation. To support this varied and ongoing evaluation work that occurs across the foundation, evaluation policies aim to identify cross-cutting functions of evaluation. They outline norms, expectations, and best practices to encourage consistency in evaluation practice. By doing so, these policies seek to provide internal stakeholders with enough direction to make decisions that align with organizational expectations and goals.

At Hewlett, program officers are charged with commissioning and using evaluations. Evaluation staff serve principally as internal consultants and technical advisors. Therefore, Hewlett's evaluation policy aims to communicate why and how evaluation is conducted in hopes that internal stakeholders can commission, conduct, and use evaluations in accordance with expectations. As the policy states:

The purpose of this document is to advance the Foundation's existing work so that our evaluation practices become more consistent across the organization. We hope to create more common understanding of our philosophy, purpose, and expectations regarding evaluation as well as clarify staff roles and available support. With more consistency and shared understanding, we expect less wheel re-creation across program areas, greater learning from each other's efforts, and faster progress in designing meaningful evaluations and applying the results. (Twersky & Lindblom, 2012, p. 3)

The policy communicates Hewlett's evaluation philosophy and suggests actions to help simplify decision making.

The intent to detail internal processes and how they vary may explain why Hewlett had the longest evaluation policy of all 12 reviewed in this study. About two thirds of the 30-page document is dedicated to specifying evaluation practice (Kinarsky & Christie, 2022). The policy begins by outlining roles and responsibilities of foundation staff and then guides them through how to plan, implement, and ultimately use evaluations. Illustrative examples are integrated throughout the document. They describe how a suggested practice is performed by other programs or propose questions that can be asked when hiring an external evaluator.

By surfacing their approach to evaluation and specifying cross-cutting functions, foundations provide a shared language for discussing evaluation. For example, at the MacArthur Foundation, where evaluation staff are embedded in program teams, the evaluation policy intends to identify and detail aspects of evaluation practice that should remain consistent across the foundation at the enterprise level. The evaluation director explained:

We have standards that sit outside of each individual program area and are developed at the enterprise level. They outline expectations for evaluation that allow for consistency at an enterprise level and flexibility at a program level.

The policy at MacArthur connects a decentralized evaluation team around a shared set of values and standards for evaluation. It sets a broad vision for how evaluation should be practiced, helping internal stakeholders understand the foundation's evaluation approach. In addition to standardizing evaluation across program areas, MacArthur also viewed the evaluation policy as a way of standardizing practice over time. Ideally, by developing an evaluation policy, there

would not be a need to make major alterations to evaluation practice as inevitable leadership or strategy changes occurred.

3. Identify When Evaluations Should Vary and How

In addition to specifying how evaluation practice should remain consistent across the foundation, evaluation policies also intend to outline when and how evaluation needs to adjust to the local context. The Gates evaluation policy explicitly states that the intent of it is to help internal stakeholders adapt their evaluation practice to their context:

Because the foundation supports a diverse range of partners and projects, it is necessary to have a clear organizational understanding of how evaluation should vary to best inform decision-making across each of these areas. (Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation, n.d., p. 1)

Given that Gates funds global initiatives ranging from malaria prevention to improving student outcomes, the policy seeks to give internal stakeholders a clear understanding of when and how to vary evaluations. In fact, most of the foundations interviewed had diverse funding priorities. To have an evaluation practice that generates meaningful findings, evaluation policies specify when and how practice should vary.

To accommodate varied programmatic goals and approaches, it is important to delineate between aspects of evaluation that need to be held consistent across an organization and those that should be varied. Directors found that once cross-cutting components of evaluation practice were identified, it was then necessary to determine how context should amend evaluation practice. For example, one evaluation director explained:

We had to think through when we vary. Are we varying to customize something that meets the needs, context, and environment that we're working in? Or are we varying something that's a principle? We needed to be really clear, so we had something to fall back on.

The Rockefeller Foundation evaluation policy was designed to encourage adaptation to the local context. It was also intended to motivate departments across the Foundation to develop their own evaluation policies, as well as inform the design of those policies. The evaluation policy, adapted in 2017, is a set of principles seeking to communicate a vision for evaluation practice that encourages adaptation. The evaluation director explained:

We don't want to be tied to one process, because we understand that every new programmatic work will probably look a little bit different in terms of how we measure, monitor, and evaluate....So rather than having a policy that is very prescriptive, we've developed a set of principles that we're holding ourselves accountable to. But that might drive the way this work ends up differently for different types of programs.

Foundations tend to have disparate funding priorities that change over time. This requires development of broad expertise across sectors. It also impacts how foundations evaluate. To support adaptation, evaluation policies may be designed to identify which aspects of practice will need to adjust to particular evaluation contexts and purposes.

5.2. Internal influence (4–7)

Extant research has begun to detail how evaluation policies support or constrain evaluation practice across a range of sectors. In the current section, we summarize how study participants' policies have influenced evaluation practice. We identified four areas of internal influence. First, evaluation policies allow internal stakeholders to better understand why and how evaluation is practiced. Second, the policies enable staff to better adapt evaluations to unique contexts. Third, these policies have helped evaluation directors and staff better understand and execute their duties. And fourth, policy formulation was beneficial for surfacing implicit understandings of evaluation and delineating how evaluation is

practiced at each foundation.

4. Evaluation Philosophy is Consistently Understood and Practice is More Consistent

As described in the previous section, the most common motivation for developing an evaluation policy was to identify cross-cutting functions of evaluation. Foundations want to make clear how their evaluations are conducted, in particular specifying which aspects need to remain consistent, and which should vary. Evaluation directors reported that establishing evaluation policies created more clarity and cohesion. For example, one said that it had “led to complete consistency. There is something we are all driving towards that's a certain threshold of rigor, a certain threshold of the types of things or the range of things that we're doing in each space.”

The evaluation directors also said that their organizations' policies clarified the importance and purpose of evaluation. According to the Duke Endowment's evaluation director, the policy helped bring more clarity to the foundation's evaluation practice by making its importance explicit:

There are all kinds of mismatched goals at different levels of the organization, and those all connect to or impact what you can do with evaluation. Having them down on paper certainly helps. It helps to have something of a shared understanding of what the purposes are for evaluation and, by extension, the purpose of a philanthropic organization. We're here to have a social benefit, and evaluation can help drive that very basic point home when it's not always so obvious.

In short, the policy makes clear that evaluation is a core function and helps advance the foundation's mission to improve the social good.

In addition to this more visionary aspect, evaluation policies also compel specific evaluation practices that are “non-negotiable.” At Hewlett, for example, the evaluation director said that internal stakeholders are less likely to question things—such as wide dissemination of results—when they are prescribed in the policy: “It's amazing. Being able to point to the policy and say we have a principle of sharing, that says we share what we're learning. People don't question it.” Thus, having a policy minimizes decision making and increases efficiency, since the same conversation does not need to occur across multiple program areas or evaluations. Key features of evaluation practice are predetermined and detailed, which allows internal stakeholders to focus attention on other, more context-dependent concerns.

5. Staff Know When and How to Vary Evaluation Practice

Another important aspect of generating more consistent evaluation practice is specifying when it should vary. The evaluation directors we interviewed reported that their evaluation policies support internal stakeholders with tailoring evaluations to local context without compromising rigor. As noted earlier, the same foundation may have dozens of evaluations occurring at the same time. These evaluations may be in very different program areas—such as education or climate change—and have different purposes, from determining the success of a 6-year strategy to collecting baseline data for a new initiative.

The design and methodology aspect of evaluation practice was prioritized in the evaluation policies written by foundations—in fact, it was the only component present in every policy. Furthermore, across all policies, more text was devoted to this component than any other (citation omitted). This emphasis on design and methodology is in part because foundations recommend that the method of inquiry follow the purpose of the evaluation. At Gates, for example, this approach is referred to as “fit to purpose,” which “allows for a range of methods, including qualitative and quantitative data collection and analysis” (Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation, n.d., p. 3). The policy reframes evaluation quality and rigor by affirming that

evaluation should prioritize alignment between purpose and method. As the Gates evaluation director explained:

Recently, there has been a belief that if it is not an RCT, then it's not useful. However, the policy also prevents against just getting a couple quotes from a couple of satisfied people. I think it's useful that there is a reminder to think about the appropriate methodology. It is a simple but important reminder that the answer to a question on methodology is and will always be, "it depends."

Evaluation policies encourage evaluations that respond to the local context and embrace broad methodological choices. They have decentralized decision making and provided guidance on how to vary evaluation practice.

The evaluation director at Gates acknowledged that while the policy helped him understand the vision for evaluation at the foundation when he first started, it is not something he often revisits. For him, the policy is less relevant on a day-to-day basis because it disperses autonomy to staff working in different strategy areas:

I was reminded why I don't think about the evaluation policy when I looked at it again today in preparation for our call. The policy says, "We do a lot of different things, so it's up to the individual strategies to figure out their evaluation plans." That's how I interpret the policy....As I read it, it doesn't really offer much guidance, except to say we think evaluation is important. But how, why, when, and with who you do evaluation depends on the kind of work you are doing. The policy puts trust in the folks doing the individual strategies to figure it out.

The policy creates a structure for evaluation practice that prioritizes the local context. It gives evaluation staff situated in different strategy areas the responsibility of determining the correct evaluation approach.

The Hewlett policy also does not enforce how evaluation is practiced across the foundation. In addition to setting a broad philosophy for evaluation practice, it has prompts for internal stakeholders to consider when doing evaluations. These prompts may guide how stakeholders conduct or use evaluation, but the policy does not enforce it. The evaluation director explained:

It is a set of guidelines. It doesn't force people to do A, B, or C. Instead, it says, "These are the questions you should be asking yourself as you go through strategy development, implementation, refresh, and sometimes exit." ...Since they are principles and not demands, we're not entirely living by our principles.

Rather than strive for strict adherence to the guidelines or principles set forth in their policies, the foundations appear to favor an evaluation practice that is tailored to the unique context of each program area and each evaluation.

6. Evaluation Staff Have More Clarity on How to Guide Organization-Wide Evaluation Practice

By outlining how evaluation is practiced at each foundation, the policies provide evaluation directors and their teams greater clarity and more authority. Designing, conducting, analyzing, and using evaluations involves a lot of decision making, often by various stakeholders over a long period of time. Having key components of evaluation practice detailed in a policy can make it easier for directors to offer consistent guidance.

For example, one foundation regularly holds grantmaking strategy meetings where evaluations are discussed. At the time of the interview, the foundation's internal stakeholders were advocating for prioritizing RCTs, irrespective of the evaluation's purpose. Rather than repeatedly explain the need to first identify the purpose of an evaluation and then select the appropriate methodology, evaluation directors can point these internal stakeholders to the justification outlined in the policy document:

When we have a debate about if there is a hierarchy of evidence... that is something that keeps coming up....I say, "Let's look at our guiding principles." Then they say "Oh! Look at that. In our own guiding principles, we have the idea that methodology has to follow purpose. So, I guess there isn't just one methodology that is at the top of the heap, right?" So, we do use the policy. It's nice to point to our principles and say, "Remember, this is the framework we work within." It sometimes helps solve disagreements.

Additionally, study participants said that their evaluation policies have helped them better understand their job responsibilities, influenced the guidance they give, and informed the materials they generate. For example, one director said that the foundation's evaluation principles "really permeate everything. They inform any advice I offer to staff, as well as all the tools that I provide. The policy helps me be clear in my advice and my guidance."

7. The Process of Developing an Evaluation Policy is Beneficial

Evaluation directors also indicated that the process of developing an evaluation policy was advantageous for the organization. Specifically, it presented an opportunity to reflect on the evaluation principles the foundation deemed important and then discuss the practices associated with these principles. For example, Rockefeller recently revised its evaluation policy to reflect organizational changes spearheaded by its new president. Once the evaluation team drafted the policy, they shared it with internal stakeholders across the organization. Those conversations surfaced aspects of evaluation practice valued at the foundation, which led to alterations to the evaluation policy. For instance, one of their principles is that evaluations need to be objective and independent so that findings are credible to a broad range of stakeholders. However, another principle is that evaluations need to fit the purpose of the evaluation. Conversations during policy development surfaced a tension between these principles:

Internal conversations have been really helpful in terms of getting us on the same page. We had a nice back and forth around the independence principle. At first, it fell off because we thought, "Well, if evaluation is user-centric and impact-oriented, and the user wants an independent evaluation, then it'll be independent. But if they want a developmental evaluation, then it won't be independent." However, during our internal conversations it turned out that right now we value independence. So, it circled its way back to being a principle.

In this case, discussing a draft of the evaluation policy with internal stakeholders helped clarify understanding of how evaluation should be practiced across the organization.

At Kansas Health, the process of writing an evaluation policy was instrumental to defining the role and responsibilities of an evaluation director. The current director is only the second person to have this role, and the first to exclusively focus on evaluation:

Writing it down is beneficial in a lot of ways. It has forced me to have more clarity that I wouldn't have otherwise. It has also provided time for reflection, which has been so important in figuring out what is working and what is not. It has helped me hone in on what is a value add.

Relatedly, the development of Hewlett's evaluation policy surfaced the need for a full-time staff person dedicated to upholding the foundation's evaluation principles and helping staff apply them in their practice. The job description was integrated into the policy document and used to hire the current evaluation officer.

5.3. External intent (8–9)

In addition to improving internal alignment, foundations develop and share their evaluation policies to explain their evaluation approach to external stakeholders. As we discuss in this section, this is done for

two reasons. First, foundations want their current and prospective grantees to better understand how evaluation is practiced and used at the foundation. By being forthright, they seek to set realistic expectations about how the foundation evaluates and what impact it may have on grantees. Second, foundations believe that how they perform evaluation is important to share with the sector. They have invested resources in their evaluation practice and want to disseminate their internal beliefs and lessons learned to the broader field.

8. Explain Evaluation Requirements and Expectations to Grantees

Evaluation directors identified two broad reasons for sharing evaluation requirements and expectations with current and prospective grantees. First, disclosing this information can help prospective grantees write better grant applications. As one evaluation director explained, “I think it is helpful for external people to understand our mental model. So, if they want to apply for grants, maybe this is helpful for them as they write it.” Second, sharing evaluation requirements from the outset may help foster more transparent and positive relationships between funders and their grantees. For example, if a foundation is committed to tracking student attendance data, but the grantee does not have the capacity to conduct such data collection, the resulting tension could lead to an adverse relationship with negative funding consequences for the grantee. Therefore, a foundation’s evaluation requirements and expectations are important considerations for grantees to understand before applying for or accepting funds.

The Wallace Foundation published its evaluation policy online after realizing that its evaluation expectations were sometimes overwhelming to grantees. Now, prospective grantees are invited to review the evaluation policy before applying. The evaluation director explained:

Having grantees find out about all the research requirements after they’ve gotten the grant led to some difficult, awkward, and problematic conversations and relationships. It didn’t take many iterations of that before we started letting people know in the earliest possible minute about our approach. We found that being explicit causes some organizations to not go ahead with the application process because it’s not a fit with them. That is totally appropriate, and we always tell them they are eligible to be considered for future initiatives. The folks who do go ahead are not surprised and are okay with participating in the research.

After some trial and error, the foundation recognized that not having an explicit document led to confusion and frustration. Rather than sharing information piecemeal, the evaluation policy is intended to give grantees and their foundation contacts a shared mental model and language to discuss evaluation expectations.

9. Communicate Evaluation Philosophy and Practices to External Stakeholders

The second external audience for evaluation policies is rather wide ranging. As foundations continue to invest in evaluation, they are generating new knowledge that may be of value to their peers in philanthropy. In addition to sharing findings, foundations are sharing their evaluation philosophy and practices. One reason for doing so is to facilitate dialogue and learning with their peers. For example, as one evaluation director explained, “We believe there are things we’re doing that would be good to share with others so that they can learn from our experience.” Another noted, “We felt that the way that we did work—the way we made grants and the process for monitoring and evaluating them—was the thing that was unique to the foundation.” Overall, the development of evaluation policies is a way for foundations to demonstrate their commitment to evaluation. Evaluation policies enable foundations to share internal practices and processes with the field and contribute to an evolving understanding of how evaluation should be utilized in the philanthropic sector.

5.4. External influence (10–11)

In this final subsection, we discuss how evaluation policies influence external stakeholders. We describe how publicly disseminating evaluation policies has helped external stakeholders better understand the evaluation expectations and practices of their partner foundations. We also describe how evaluation directors are reading the evaluation policies of other foundations and reflecting on their internal practices.

10. Current and Prospective Grantees Better Understand the Foundation’s Evaluation Expectations and Practices

Evaluation directors reported that having an explicit evaluation policy has led to more satisfied grantees. For example, Wallace has a very particular, intensive approach to evaluation and research. As described above, the foundation’s evaluation policy is shared and discussed a lot with grantees because it helps set realistic expectations. Their grantees are more satisfied:

It is burdensome and a pain in the neck to be part of a Wallace initiative. But if you know what you’re in for, then it is manageable and not that surprising. It winds up being okay with people.

The evaluation directors believed that being up front and explicit with grantees about what they should expect had helped facilitate more positive working relationships.

Policies are not read only by prospective grantees; they are also reviewed by external evaluators hired by foundations. For example, program officers at Packard rely on external evaluators to develop and execute evaluation plans. The evaluation policy communicates the foundation’s expectations and processes so external evaluators’ work aligns with internal expectations:

Our contractors look at and use the guiding principles. Just this week, I received an email from one of them about the guiding principles. External consultants help teams draft and implement their measurement, evaluation, and learning plans. At that time, they are referencing the evaluation principles.

Since each foundation articulates a unique vision and approach, evaluation policies are helpful because they orient external stakeholders to how evaluation is done in each context.

11. Foundations Benefit from Reviewing and Reflecting on Each Other’s Policies

Foundations look to what their peer institutions are doing when developing or revising their evaluation policies, in part to identify what they do or do not want to emulate. For example, one evaluation director explained, “As I prepare to update our policy, I first did a scan of what other folks are doing.” Evaluation directors reported looking across the sector for examples of evaluation policies. They described critically analyzing policies and reflecting on how their own foundation’s policy may look different.

6. Conclusion

Through interviews with evaluation directors at foundations that have publicly available evaluation policies, the current study represents a first step in documenting why evaluation policies are developed and what impact, if any, they have on evaluation practice. This is one of the first studies to explore these topics.

We found that the intent and influence of publicly available evaluation policies can be divided into two broad categories: internal and external. The responsibility for commissioning, conducting, and using evaluations is often dispersed across a broad range of internal stakeholders, such as board members, the president, evaluation staff, and program staff. Evaluation policies seek to improve internal alignment around evaluation practice by communicating a broad philosophy and purpose for evaluation. Policies also specify when and how evaluation

practices should remain consistent and when they should vary across a foundation.

The evaluation directors described the importance of process use (Patton, 1998)- how the very process of writing an evaluation policy can offer a foundation the opportunity to clarify its approach to evaluation and articulate a shared mental model. Upon implementation of the policy, evaluation directors believed that evaluation practice was improved in a few ways. First, they saw more consistency in how different stakeholders conducted and used evaluation. Next, there was greater clarity around when and how evaluation practice should vary by context. Lastly, written policies enabled evaluation directors to better support evaluation as an activity and priority across the organization. A written policy helps to organize and simplify how evaluation is practiced, which likely results in clearer and more consistent guidance for a range of key stakeholders, and importantly grantees. Future research in this area could explore more deeply the process of developing evaluation policies, what kind of process use occurs, and what implementation strategies support accurate policy interpretation and application.

Another intent of an evaluation policy is to explain a foundation's evaluation approach to external stakeholders. External stakeholders include grantees or prospective grantees, external evaluators, the general public, and other foundations. The policy may explain internal processes to grantees, offer direction to external evaluators, share internal opinions on evaluations with other foundations, and inform the public on the foundation's internal practices. As a result, the foundation may have improved relationships with its grantees and external consultants. Foundations may also use the policies written by others to reflect on how their own evaluations are conducted.

Prior research has shown that evaluation policies can be interpreted inconsistently across internal stakeholders (Christie & Fierro, 2012; Dillman, 2014). The evaluation directors in the current study identified numerous internal and external stakeholders who they thought would benefit from evaluation policies, but it is unclear how these stakeholders interpreted and used them. Interviews with various stakeholders, such as external evaluators, program officers, and grantees, would produce valuable insights. Alternatively, simulation studies could be used to address this gap. For example, external evaluators could be given an evaluation scenario and an evaluation policy and then be asked to design an appropriate evaluation. Simulation studies have revealed fundamental differences across evaluation theorists and are a promising next step for research on evaluation policy (Eisenberg et al., 2005; Mark et al., 2009).

Our interviews with evaluation directors revealed that many foundations drafted their policies to strengthen their evaluation practice by articulating their purposes for and approaches to the work. The policies tended to outline a shared approach to the cross-cutting functions of evaluation while leaving room for stakeholders to make context-specific decisions. The study participants believed that by specifying how to use and manage evaluations, the policies fostered more intentional practices and generated more meaningful evaluations. Notably, not just the evaluation policies themselves but also the discussions during policy development enabled the foundations to be more intentional in evaluation practice.

Overall, our findings on the intent and influence of evaluation policies are largely consistent with those outlined by Trochim (2009). The policies encourage consistency of practice across each foundation, which is necessary because responsibility for evaluation is typically dispersed across various stakeholders. They are also an educational tool that helps explain each foundation's approach to evaluation. Foundation staff use other organizations' explicit policies to reflect on and adapt their own evaluation practices. Likewise, grantees and external contractors review policies to understand and align to internal expectations.

Author note

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CRediT authorship contribution statement

Kinarsky: Conceptualization, Methodology, Validation, Formal analysis, Investigation, Writing – original draft, Project administration.
Christie: Conceptualization, Methodology, Writing – review & editing, Supervision.

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